region? Gold may well have been one such resource which, as we shall see, has been found here.

The region also had a strategic significance. More than a thousand years after Ashoka, among a bunch of inscriptions that either referred to Maski (called ‘Mosangi’, ‘Musangi’, or ‘Mosage’) as the chief town of the administrative region or as a political capital, is an eleventh century CE epigraph which alludes to it as a battlefield. In the list of conquests of the Tamil king Rajendra Chola I, which ranged from Sri Lanka and Kerala to Orissa and Bengal, is the vanquishing of Jayasimha, identified with the Chalukya king Jayasimha II, who was described as being put to flight at Musangi.[37] Even though Jayasimha’s base was at Kalyani, while Rajendra Chola came from the deep south, the fact that the invading Chola king defeated the Karnataka-based Chalukya in the vicinity of Maski is a pointer to its critical location.

We can glimpse similar subcontinental links in the time of the iron-using society of the region. The inhabitants used beads that may have originated from areas very far from ancient Karnataka. Beads in several kinds of raw materials, ranging from those made of carnelian and garnet to terracotta and paste, have been found here. Lapis lazuli, shell, and coral are also in evidence: the lapis was probably of Afghan origin, while shell and coral in this interior area would have travelled along routes that linked it with the western coast. The raw materials would have come in with commercial people of all kinds: traveller-traders from the north-west carrying lapis with them, and people from this belt travelling there and returning with saleable goods. The material yields of trade add to our image of the intersection between these regions at huge distances from each other. This intersection, as we saw, was evident from the presence of scribes in Karnataka–Andhra accomplished in Kharoshthi and employed by the Mauryan provincial administration.